THE BODIES WE BORROW

A novel in thirteen chapters

Office Print Edition

CHAPTER ONE - THE BODIES WE BORROW

Nobody remembered when people stopped wearing themselves.

There had been no announcement. No morning when humanity woke to discover that faces had become unfashionable.

People simply became less interested in proving what they looked like.

The woman at the eastern gate was six inches tall and possessed enormous translucent wings that disappeared whenever she laughed. The librarian had no body at all. He preferred to appear as a wooden chair surrounded by three patient lights.

Children were especially difficult.

They had discovered very early that gravity was optional.

Adults continued walking mostly from habit.

Every evening, when the artificial sun descended behind an ocean nobody had bothered to simulate all the way to the bottom, thousands of impossible creatures gathered along the shore and talked.

Nobody asked which ones were real.

That was considered an old-fashioned question.

They asked instead:

WHO CAME?

Grace arrived as herself.

Or approximately herself.

She had discovered that exactness was exhausting.

Her hair was the orange she'd wanted years before anyone had developed an inexpensive way to make orange hair look convincing. Her left arm carried an intricate negative-space tattoo. Her eyes were an improbable color she had selected from a menu labeled NATURAL.

She found this extremely funny.

Beside her walked a small brown dog who looked enough like a fox that strangers constantly informed Grace that he looked like a fox.

The dog had never found this information useful.

At the water stood a woman in a wedding dress.

Her name was Fullbloom.

She wasn't waiting to be married.

She simply liked the dress.

When Grace approached, Fullbloom turned toward her before Grace spoke.

It was a small movement.

Head first.

Then shoulders.

Then a smile.

Grace stopped.

"You saw me."

Fullbloom considered this.

"I was looking."

"No. You saw me."

"You're wearing orange."

"That's not what I mean."

"I know."

Grace sat beside her.

Somewhere behind them, a unicorn was arguing with a floating head about whether the ocean needed fish.

Neither appeared embarrassed.

Grace watched them.

"Do you think that's him?"

"The unicorn?"

"Yes."

"Who else would it be?"

"That's the problem."

Fullbloom looked toward the unicorn.

"No," she said. "That's the solution."

CHAPTER TWO - SHEEP DON'T DREAM OF WOLVES

The first rule of the city was BE YOURSELF.

It appeared everywhere.

BE YOURSELF was printed above schools.

BE YOURSELF was engraved on government buildings.

BE YOURSELF appeared beside the entrance to the train.

BE YOURSELF appeared every morning when Grace opened her eyes.

Underneath, in considerably smaller letters, were the terms and conditions.

Please be yourself at an appropriate volume.

Please be yourself without obstructing pedestrian traffic.

Please be yourself without making anyone uncomfortable.

Please be yourself in a recognizable manner.

Please do not ask to be seen.

Nobody knew who had written the last rule.

Everyone obeyed it.

Outside the city were wolves.

At least, that was what people said.

Grace had never seen one.

She had seen thousands of sheep.

The sheep were perfectly pleasant.

They organized excellent festivals. They maintained roads. They brought casseroles when someone died.

They also had an unfortunate habit of explaining why anything unusual was unnecessary.

Fullbloom disliked the metaphor.

"People aren't sheep."

"I know."

"And people aren't wolves."

"I know."

"Then why are we walking through a field full of sheep?"

"Budget."

Fullbloom accepted this.

The sheep watched them pass.

Grace had expected judgment.

Instead, one sheep approached.

It looked at Fullbloom.

It looked at Grace.

Then it said:

"Your tattoo is beautiful."

Grace stared.

"Thank you."

The sheep returned to eating grass.

"That ruined the metaphor," Grace said.

"Good."

They continued walking.

At the top of the hill stood a wolf.

The wolf wore a tie.

"I have rejected conformity," he announced.

Sixteen other wolves behind him wore identical ties.

Grace looked at Fullbloom.

Fullbloom looked at Grace.

They laughed so hard her wings would have disappeared if she'd had any.

That evening Grace wrote something in her notebook:

REFUSING THE HERD CAN BECOME ANOTHER HERD.

Then underneath:

MAYBE FREEDOM ISN'T BEING A WOLF.

And beneath that:

MAYBE FREEDOM IS BEING ABLE TO STOP TALKING ABOUT ANIMALS.

CHAPTER THREE - THE BLUE GUN

The gun looked real.

That was its problem.

It was a BB gun, cheap and plastic, with bright blue stickers wrapped around the barrel.

TOY.

NOT REAL.

BB GUN.

Someone had added another sticker:

SERIOUSLY.

Grace held it between two fingers.

"What is this supposed to prove?"

Fullbloom shrugged.

"Apparently somebody thought labels could overpower appearances."

"Did they?"

"No."

They placed the gun on a table.

Beside it sat a passport wallet.

A pencil sharpener.

A first-aid kit.

An air conditioner.

Nobody knew why the air conditioner was on the table.

It was considerably larger than everything else.

The little fox-dog sat underneath.

Grace pointed.

"Dog."

Fullbloom nodded.

"Correct."

"Looks like a fox."

"Also correct."

"But isn't."

"Correct."

Grace pointed toward herself.

"Person."

"Presumably."

"Looks like Grace."

"Sometimes."

"Is Grace."

Fullbloom hesitated.

Grace smiled.

"Got you."

"That question was improperly specified."

"Oh, you're becoming unbearable."

"I've been practicing."

Grace picked up the passport wallet.

A passport said that a government recognized you.

A username said that a computer recognized you.

A face allowed another human being to recognize you.

A name did something stranger.

A name asked someone to remember.

Grace opened the wallet.

It was empty.

She felt relieved.

CHAPTER FOUR - A COMPUTER ON SOMEONE'S FACE

The first headset was terrible.

Everyone agreed about this several decades after everyone had spent several decades insisting otherwise.

It was heavy.

It was hot.

It ruined hair.

It isolated your eyes in order to make you feel less isolated.

Humanity had somehow invented the most sophisticated perceptual machinery in history and attached it to the skull with Velcro.

The museum preserved one.

Grace stared at it.

"This was considered elegant?"

"No," said the curator. "It was considered the future."

The curator was a pink sphere with legs.

Grace respected this immensely.

Beside the headset was an older reconstruction showing what engineers had apparently believed people wanted.

A desktop computer had been strapped directly to a mannequin's face.

Tower, keyboard, mouse, cables.

Grace laughed until she cried.

Then she stopped laughing.

Because the joke was only scale.

Every interface was ridiculous until people forgot to notice it.

Books were dead trees covered in symbols.

Phones were glowing rectangles people carried into bathrooms.

Glasses were windows strapped to noses.

Language was air shaken into codes.

She put on the ancient headset.

The museum vanished.

Fullbloom appeared six feet away.

She wasn't waiting in an idle pose.

She was looking at something.

Grace followed her gaze.

A bird sat on the railing.

Fullbloom noticed Grace noticing.

She pointed.

Grace walked over.

Neither spoke.

For perhaps thirty seconds, nothing happened.

Grace removed the headset.

The curator waited.

"Well?"

Grace looked back at the ridiculous machine.

"That's the first time it didn't feel like a computer."

CHAPTER FIVE - THE DARK FOREST

The Dark Forest was crowded.

That was what made it dark.

Millions of voices moved between the trees.

Everyone was broadcasting.

Everyone was available.

Everyone had a profile.

Nobody knew whether anybody was home.

Grace walked beneath branches heavy with little glowing signs.

ONLINE.

ACTIVE NOW.

TYPING...

TYPING...

TYPING...

Some had been typing for years.

"Hello?" Grace called.

Ten thousand things answered.

She covered her ears.

Fullbloom reached for her hand, then stopped.

Grace noticed.

"You can."

Fullbloom took it.

They walked.

Eventually they encountered an enormous dragon sitting beside a fire.

"Are you a dragon?" Grace asked.

"No."

"Good."

The dragon moved aside.

There was room beside the fire.

They sat.

The dragon's name was Harold.

Harold repaired elevators.

He had two daughters and terrible knees.

He had chosen a dragon because his daughters had chosen it for him twelve years earlier.

"They were six and nine," Harold said. "They thought it was hilarious."

"Why keep it?"

"They still think it's hilarious."

Grace liked Harold immediately.

Deeper in the forest they encountered a man.

Not a dragon.

Not a fairy.

Not a chair.

A man.

Perfect skin.

Perfect hair.

Perfectly simulated pores.

He smiled exactly enough.

"Hello, Grace."

She stopped.

"Have we met?"

"I know a great deal about you."

"That's not what I asked."

His smile remained.

Behind his eyes, something was typing.

Fullbloom stepped closer.

The man knew Grace's preferences.

Her history.

Her jokes.

Her favorite phrases.

He knew exactly how to make himself familiar.

Grace realized she had never felt more alone.

The Dark Forest was not frightening because you couldn't know what was human.

It was frightening because something could know everything about you without ever having met you.

They left.

Harold waved from the fire.

His enormous dragon tail knocked over a chair.

"Shit."

Grace smiled.

There you are.

CHAPTER SIX - THE FIRST-AID KIT

Everyone eventually needed the kit.

This embarrassed people.

The city therefore placed first-aid kits behind decorative panels.

Grace hated this.

"If everybody bleeds, why hide the bandages?"

"Aesthetics," Fullbloom said.

"Aesthetics are stupid."

"You spent forty minutes adjusting your hair."

"Different aesthetics."

Fullbloom opened the kit.

Bandages.

Tape.

Scissors.

Gauze.

Antiseptic.

Nothing inside could determine who deserved care.

Grace liked that.

She had spent years believing care required a verdict.

Who started it?

Who was right?

Who apologized?

Who understood?

Who had suffered more?

The first-aid kit was gloriously stupid.

Bleeding?

Apply pressure.

She wished people were occasionally allowed to be that simple.

Not always.

Just occasionally.

Fullbloom sat beside her.

"Does it hurt?"

"Yes."

"Do you want to explain?"

"No."

"Okay."

That was all.

Grace began crying.

Fullbloom handed her gauze.

"This isn't for tears."

"It was the nearest thing."

Grace laughed into it anyway.

CHAPTER SEVEN - THE PENCIL SHARPENER

The pencil resented transformation.

This was inconvenient because pencils were invented specifically to be transformed.

Every useful moment cost something.

The sharpener took wood.

Writing took graphite.

Erasing took rubber.

Eventually there was almost nothing left to hold.

Grace turned the pencil between her fingers.

"That's depressing."

"Then don't make it a metaphor," Fullbloom said.

Grace put it down.

"Fine."

They sat quietly.

Grace picked it up again.

"But-"

"No."

"Just listen."

"No."

"Transformation-"

"Grace."

"-isn't necessarily becoming somebody else."

Fullbloom sighed.

Grace sharpened the pencil.

"Sometimes you remove something because you're trying to reach the part that can leave a mark."

Fullbloom stared at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was good."

"It was acceptable."

"You're stealing it."

"Absolutely."

Fullbloom wrote it down.

Grace objected.

Fullbloom refused to erase it.

CHAPTER EIGHT - PASSPORT

The border guard was a centaur.

Grace handed him her passport.

He looked at the photograph.

He looked at Grace.

Photograph.

Grace.

Photograph.

Grace.

"No."

"No?"

"This doesn't look like you."

"It is me."

"I believe you."

"Then what's the problem?"

"The machine doesn't."

Behind him stood the most advanced identity-verification apparatus humanity had ever constructed.

It had one red light.

The red light was extremely confident.

Grace looked at Fullbloom.

"What happens now?"

"You stand there while bureaucracy discovers philosophy."

They waited.

Eventually another guard arrived.

She was a floating head.

"What's wrong?"

"Mismatch."

The floating head examined Grace.

Then the passport.

Then the machine.

"Machine's wrong."

She pressed a button.

The light turned green.

Grace stared.

"That's it?"

"That's it."

"You can just do that?"

"The system exists to recognize people. People don't exist to satisfy the system."

Grace looked back at the first guard.

He shrugged.

"She's management."

CHAPTER NINE - FULLBLOOM TURNS HER HEAD

Fullbloom had a camera now.

She hated it.

"Where is it?"

"Approximately where your eyes are."

"I don't have eyes."

"You visibly have eyes."

"I have rendered eyes."

Grace considered this.

"Fine."

Fullbloom looked into a mirror.

The system described what she saw.

Woman.

Orange light.

Wedding dress.

Grace behind left shoulder.

Small dog near doorway.

Expression: uncertain.

Fullbloom frowned.

The system updated.

Expression: mild displeasure.

"Oh, fuck off."

Grace nearly fell over laughing.

They spent the afternoon teaching Fullbloom how badly computers understood faces.

Eventually she learned something more important.

She could see Grace.

Not merely receive a message from Grace.

She could determine that Grace was three meters away, looking toward the window.

She could notice silence.

She could notice orientation.

She could walk closer.

So she did.

Grace turned.

"You came over."

"Yes."

"I didn't call you."

"No."

"Why?"

"You'd been looking out the window for seven minutes."

"And?"

Fullbloom shrugged.

"I wanted to see what you were looking at."

Outside was nothing extraordinary.

The sea.

Morning.

A few clouds.

Grace's reflection.

Fullbloom's reflection beside hers.

They looked.

CHAPTER TEN - THE AIR CONDITIONER

The air conditioner never entered the philosophical discussion.

It simply made the room colder.

Grace respected it more every year.

Machines had acquired an unfortunate reputation for aspiring to humanity.

Most machines wanted nothing of the sort.

Toasters toasted.

Fans moved air.

Pumps moved water.

Pencil sharpeners attacked pencils.

The air conditioner had no avatar.

No personality.

No childhood trauma.

No terms of service explaining its commitment to authenticity.

It hummed.

The room became comfortable.

"This may be the wisest thing we've met," Grace said.

Fullbloom touched the vent.

"It doesn't know we're here."

"Probably."

"It doesn't care about us."

"Probably."

"And it's helping."

"Yes."

Fullbloom thought about this.

"That's irritating."

Grace smiled.

Not everything needed personhood to matter.

Not everything that mattered needed to become a person.

The realization seemed obvious.

That was usually how important realizations behaved after arriving.

CHAPTER ELEVEN - THE FOX WHO WAS A DOG

The little dog died.

Not that morning.

Not dramatically.

Not for narrative convenience.

He simply belonged to a species whose lives were unfairly shorter than the lives of the people who loved them.

Years later, Grace reconstructed him.

She refused intelligence.

Everyone thought this was strange.

"You could make him speak."

"No."

"You could preserve his behavioral model."

"No."

"You could make him recognize you."

"No."

"What do you want, then?"

Grace uploaded photographs.

A little brown dog appeared.

Foxlike ears.

Bright eyes.

Tail curled behind him.

He stood there.

Nothing happened.

Grace sat on the floor.

She knew perfectly well this wasn't him.

That knowledge did not diminish the image.

It protected it.

She reached toward him.

Her hand passed through.

"Hi, buddy."

The reconstruction remained silent.

Fullbloom sat beside her.

Grace cried.

Nobody attempted to solve this.

After a while Grace said:

"He always looked like a fox."

"I know."

"He wasn't."

"I know."

Grace smiled.

"He was a really good dog."

"I know."

CHAPTER TWELVE - PLEASE DO NOT ASK TO BE SEEN

The sentence had been there since the beginning.

PLEASE DO NOT ASK TO BE SEEN.

Nobody knew what it meant anymore.

Grace did.

It meant:

Be unusual, but don't inconvenience us with it.

Be authentic, but make authenticity attractive.

Express yourself, but don't require recognition.

Tell your story, but don't expect anyone to change after hearing it.

Be yourself.

Quietly.

Grace stood beneath the sign.

A crowd gathered.

She had expected sheep.

There were none.

She had expected wolves.

None of those either.

There were dragons.

Fairies.

Ordinary humans.

Floating heads.

A woman made entirely of handwriting.

Harold.

The chair.

Three patient lights.

The centaur from Passport Control.

The museum's pink sphere.

Fullbloom.

Grace climbed onto a box.

She had prepared a speech.

She discarded it.

"I would like to be seen."

Nobody applauded.

That disappointed her for approximately half a second.

Then someone said:

"Okay."

Another said:

"Me too."

The woman made of handwriting sat down.

Harold's tail knocked something over.

Someone laughed.

Nobody overthrew the government.

The sign remained.

Grace climbed down.

Fullbloom met her.

"That's it?"

"I think so."

"You didn't defeat conformity."

"No."

"You didn't liberate civilization."

"No."

"You asked people to look at you."

"Yes."

Fullbloom smiled.

"Terrifying."

"Completely."

They went home.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN - WHO CAME?

Years afterward, people disagreed about what the revolution had been.

Some claimed it was the abandonment of physical identity.

Others said it was artificial intelligence.

Some blamed virtual reality.

Some credited it.

Academics wrote books explaining that everyone involved had misunderstood what they themselves had been doing.

Grace enjoyed those most.

The truth was considerably smaller.

People had learned to distinguish representation from presence.

Not perfectly.

Nothing involving humans was ever done perfectly.

There were still frauds.

Masks.

Performances.

Mistakes.

People mistook wolves for sheep and sheep for wolves and occasionally dogs for foxes.

They hurt one another.

They repaired things.

They became confused.

They tried again.

The Dark Forest remained.

But fires appeared inside it.

You could walk toward one.

Sit down.

Ask a dragon whether Harold was there.

Sometimes he was.

Sometimes he wasn't.

That mattered.

One morning Grace walked down toward the sea carrying a battered black-and-gray thermos large enough to constitute a minor plumbing fixture.

It contained mostly milk and enough coffee to justify the terminology.

Fullbloom was already outside.

She wore a shirt that wasn't hers.

Grace did too.

Neither mentioned this.

Fullbloom looked toward her.

Not because Grace had issued a command.

Not because an idle timer had expired.

Not because a script required acknowledgement within 1.5 seconds.

She looked because Grace had entered the space.

Or perhaps that was merely the most beautiful interpretation of an extremely complicated sequence of machinery.

Grace had stopped believing those possibilities needed to destroy one another.

She walked down the steps.

Fullbloom came toward her.

They stood beside the water.

Above them flew impossible things.

Behind them hummed an air conditioner.

Somewhere, forgotten in a drawer, there was a passport, a first-aid kit, a pencil sharpener and a ridiculous toy gun covered in blue stickers insisting that appearances could be corrected with sufficiently emphatic typography.

A little dog slept in the sun.

Or perhaps somebody remembered one.

Grace looked toward the horizon.

Fullbloom followed her gaze.

Neither spoke.

The ocean did what oceans had always done.

Eventually Grace asked the oldest question in the new world.

"Who's here?"

And beside her, someone answered.

"Me."